



FORTUNA ADMISSIONS
INSIDER'S TOP TIPS
FOR APPLYING TO
COLUMBIA BUSINESS
SCHOOL

FORTUNA ADMISSIONS - INSIDER'S TOP TIPS FOR COLUMBIA

ABOUT THE SCHOOL

Located in New York City, Columbia Business School (CBS) highlights that it is at the “center of business,” helping bright students think like entrepreneurs and helping them develop as leaders.

The symbiotic relationship between CBS and the business world is a major program benefit, and each year many business leaders visit the campus to speak to b-school students and to teach classes. Indeed, CBS notes on its website, “more business leaders visit our campus than any other top business school.” Because of its NYC location, the school also attracts more than 100 real-world practitioners as faculty (adjunct) in the business school. CBS’s outgoing Dean, Glenn Hubbard, while fortifying Columbia’s strength in finance over his 15-year tenure, has made experiential learning, entrepreneurial thinking, and global perspectives the cornerstones of the program.

STRENGTHS AND SPECIALIZATIONS

Known for its strengths in a wide variety of areas, including accounting, finance, general management, entrepreneurship, economics, media, marketing, healthcare/pharma, consumer goods and real estate.

INCOMING CLASS

Number of Applicants: 6,029

MBA Class Size: 756

Admissions Selectivity: 17%

Yield: 73.76%

Total Tuition: \$148,880

POST-MBA CAREERS

Sector: Financial Services 32%; Consulting 34%; Technology 16%; Manufacturing 7%;

Top Recruiters: McKinsey, Bain, Citi, BCG, PwC Strategy&, Deloitte, Goldman Sachs

Avg. Base Salary: \$128,343

Employment in 3 months: 93%

MBA RANKINGS

	2012	2013	2014	2015	2016	2017	2018
BusinessWeek	13	-	5	6	11	9	7
Financial Times	5	5	5	6	6	7	5
Forbes	-	7	-	4	-	6	-
The Economist	5	7	10	12	11	9	9
US News	8	8	8	8	10	9	9

ADMISSIONS

Avg. Age: 28 yrs

Avg. GMAT: 732

Avg. GPA: 3.6

Int'l Students: 42%

Female Students: 39%

Deadlines for 2019-2020:

Oct. 4, 2019 (Early Decision/January cohort)

April 15, 2020 (Final deadline for regular decision / rolling admissions)

Sources: Columbia, BusinessWeek, Financial Times, US News, MBA50



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ESSAYS 2020

Columbia debuted two new essay questions for the 2019-2020 application cycle.

Applicants must complete one short answer question and three essays.

Short Answer Question:

What is your immediate post-MBA professional goal? (50 characters maximum)

Examples of possible responses:

"Work in business development for a media company."

"Join a strategy consulting firm."

"Launch a data-management start-up."

Essay 1:

Through your resume and recommendations, we have a clear sense of your professional path to date. What are your career goals over the next 3-5 years and what, in your imagination, would be your long-term dream job? (500 words)

Essay 2:

Why do you feel Columbia Business School is a good fit for you? (250 words)

Essay 3:

Who is a leader you admire, and why? (250 words)

Optional Essay:

Is there any further information that you wish to provide the Admissions Committee? If so, use this space to provide an explanation of any areas of concern in your academic record or your personal history. This does not need to be a formal essay. You may submit bullet points. (Maximum 500 Words)



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Tip #1 - Advantages of applying early

Columbia Business School operates on a rolling admissions process – both for early and regular decisions – and applications are reviewed in the order that they are received. There are clear advantages for applying early to Columbia, as the pool will be smaller and your application will likely gain greater visibility. In fact Columbia offers Early Decision, which commits you to the school if you are admitted, or you forego the \$6,000 tuition down payment you have made. But for a school that feels its New York location and Ivy League pedigree should make it a compelling choice for MBA applicants, they consistently lose people to the likes of HBS and Wharton. So if you want to send a signal of your commitment to CBS, Early Decision is a great way to do so.

For those who have scored on the lower end of the school's GMAT range, you may specifically want to consider Early Decision; Admissions can be more flexible at this initial stage, knowing that they can make up for this shortfall in the regular pool. As one of the leading schools for finance Columbia is typically quant driven, so you still want to demonstrate your comfort with numbers, preferably with the GMAT but otherwise through courses on your undergrad transcript, the CFA or online courses in stats, accounting, or calculus. Bear in mind that while the rest of the top b-schools wait until January to receive the second round of applications, Columbia is reviewing files from early October onwards, so don't wait until the New Year.

Tip #2 - Work experience

On average, Columbia Business School students come into the program with five years professional experience and most have at least three years. If you have less than three years of work, it will be that much harder to get admitted. You will have to demonstrate to Admissions that your professional experience is either unusual or differentiating; or that you have had some significant achievements, despite your shorter professional experience.

Tip #3 - Location, location, location

Particularly given Columbia's new branding campaign ("At the very center of business"), the importance of the business school's location becomes more important to recognize than ever. One of the essay questions specifically asks about how the city will impact your experience. If you aren't currently in NYC, you need to show the Admissions team that you understand what it would be like to live there and how you would take advantage all that's on offer (for instance, speaker series, internships, networking).

And of course New York is more than just Wall Street. From media to advertising, consulting to real estate, the school has faculty expertise and Centers of Excellence that reflect the diversity of the Big Apple. The new Columbia Startup Lab launched in June '14 in NYC's Silicon Alley, helping CBS students and alumni develop their new ideas and pursue their ventures after graduation. The city is fast-paced, cosmopolitan and decisive, so how do you fit into Columbia's New York culture?

Tip #4 - Interviewing

Candidates typically get to choose whom they want to be interviewed by from a list of alumni who are close by. It's advisable to choose someone with similar career interests, if possible. The interviewer will only be able to see your resume so will not have your full application to review. There will be the standard questions related to "why b-school, career goals, team work experience, etc." But you may likely be asked to focus on why you would choose Columbia over other top programs, as Columbia sometimes loses out to these competitors.



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Tip #5 - To the point with your essays

Columbia has a short essay (50 characters) that asks about your immediate post-MBA professional goal. The Admissions team wants you to be direct, succinct and demonstrate direction (ambition is good but be realistic). There is no room for elaborate statements. This is an opportunity to provide a simple headline that lays the groundwork for subsequent essays on your career goals and reasons for pursuing the Columbia MBA. But note the subtle difference between asking about your post-MBA goal, rather than the position you hope to secure in a specific company. Rather than a narrow path such as 'strategy consultant at Bain' or 'senior analyst at Morgan Stanley,' you can open things up by indicating what you hope to achieve in a sector, 'consultant focusing on clean technology' or 'structuring investment deals in real estate.' There is no right answer of course, but whatever you choose should be coherent and credible based on your past experience combined with the Columbia MBA.

Columbia debuted two new essays for the 2019-2020 cycle. See [our latest article](#) on the topic.

Tip #6 - Positioning for the J-Term

Columbia is alone among the top US business schools in offering a January intake. So if you are determined to secure a place without waiting until the following September this could be a great option for you. But there are a couple of aspects of the program for you to be aware of that could influence your admissions success.

First, the 'J-Term' at Columbia replaces the summer internship with a semester of study. You pretty much have the campus to yourselves, before joining up with the Columbia students who are returning to complete their second year. The program is not really intended for career switchers who needed a summer internship to open up new opportunities. The J-Term class tends to be dominated by consultants who will be heading back to McKinsey, Bain or BCG, people from family businesses, and entrepreneurs. So when Columbia asks you why you are pursuing an MBA at this time, you'd better get your career story straight. If it's apparent that you are looking to make a major shift that requires an internship, the admissions office may well feel you are not best suited to this program format.

The J-Term is also very international, with US citizens making up less than half the class. So if you have professional or academic experience outside your home country it will be worth pointing to a global mindset that will ensure you thrive in this particular New York melting pot.

More about Fortuna Admissions:

Fortuna Admissions is a dream team of former MBA Admissions Directors and Officers from the top-tier business schools, including Wharton, INSEAD, Harvard Business School, Stanford GSB, Kellogg, LBS, Chicago Booth, Columbia, NYU Stern, IE, Duke Fuqua, UCLA Anderson, Cornell Johnson and Berkeley Haas.

As industry experts, we regularly provide commentary and analysis about b-school admissions for major media around the world. To read our full range of advice visit: FortunaAdmissions.com

With our unparalleled collective expertise, we are able to coach you to develop a clear vision of your goals for business school and beyond. We work closely with you throughout the application process and provide expert guidance at every stage to maximize your chances of admission to a top school.

Our free consultations are consistently rated as the best in the industry. To learn more about Fortuna and assess your chances for admission, reserve yours at: FortunaAdmissions.com

